

Session 10: Giants in Ancient Near Eastern Context

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 6:1-4 is the origin story of Babylon, the empire that will take Israel into exile.
- The Hebrew Bible offers a sophisticated critique of monarchy.
- The problem of evil originates in both human and spiritual rebellion, and the Nephilim and the other giant warrior kings of the Hebrew Bible are a constant reminder of the spiritual forces at work.

The Sons of *Elohim* and the Giant Nephilim in Ancient Cultural Context

Summary so far: Genesis 6 is telling us that all of these violent and very tall warrior kings who spread death and terror throughout the ancient world originated in a spiritual rebellion. The concept of human-divine warriors was a common idea in the culture of the ancient Near East. Many ancient empires, especially Egypt, Assyria, and Babylon claimed that their empires were founded by giant warriors who were half human and half deity.

There was a widespread tradition in ancient Assyria and Babylon that the most ancient roots of civilization and kingship came from the gods from before the time of the flood. These traditions are expressed in a series of ancient texts called The Sumerian King Lists, which are found in multiple versions. For more about these ancient texts, see *The Sumerian King Lists* by Thorkild Jacobsen (1939) and *Enoch and the Growth of an Apocalyptic Tradition*, chapter 2, by James VanderKam (1984).

The Sumerian King Lists	Genesis 5
There are 10 kings from the creation of kingship to the flood and right after the flood.	There are 10 generations from Adam to the flood of Noah, who lives after the flood.
The first king, Alulim, is appointed by the oldest gods.	Adam and Eve (= ‘adam, “humanity”) is appointed as the royal image of God to rule all creation.
The final king is chosen to survive the flood.	Noah, the tenth, is chosen to survive the flood.
The 10 kings rule for hyperbolically long periods of time (two versions are based on WB 62 and WB	The 10 patriarchs live for long periods of time
Similarities Between the Sumerian King List and Genesis 5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

The Sumerian King Lists	Genesis 5
444; see Jacobsen, <i>The Sumerian King Lists</i>, 70-77). Alulim - 67,200 or 28,000 Alalgar - 72,000 or 36,000 Kidunnu - 72,000 or 43,200 Alimma - 21,600 or 28,800 Dumuzi - 21,600 or 36,000 Enmenluanna - 21,600 or 28,800 Enmeduranki - 36,000 or 21,000 Enmeduranna - 72,000 or 18,000 Ubartutu - 28,000 or [NA] Ziusudra - 36,000 or [NA]	Adam - 930 years Seth - 912 years Enosh - 905 years Qenan - 910 years Mahalalel - 895 years Yared - 962 years Enoch - 365 years Methushelah - 969 years Lemek - 777 years Noah - 950 years
The seventh king, Enmeduranki, lived through the flood and has a unique role among the gods.	The seventh patriarch, Enoch, does not die but is translated to God's realm because of his special relationship with God.
<i>Similarities Between the Sumerian King List and Genesis 5. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).</i>	

The Lineage of the Apkallu and the Kings of Babylon

“In Mesopotamian religion, the term apkallu is used for the legendary creatures endowed with extraordinary wisdom. Seven in number, they are the culture heroes from before the Flood. Some of the mythological speculations in which they figure have exerted influence on certain biblical and post-biblical traditions. Examples are the figure of Enoch and the tale of the Nephilim (Gen. 6:1-4) ... [T]he ‘seven apkallu ... are at the service of the high God Ea. Ea is called the “sage among the gods” (apkallu ili)’ ... A variety of wisdom traditions from the antediluvian period were supposedly passed on by the apkallu. We also learn from the ‘Myth of the Seven Sages’ that the later apkallu were ‘of human descent, whom the lord Ea has endowed with wisdom’ ... The seven sages were created in the river and served as ‘those who ensured the correct functioning of the plans of heaven and earth.’”

Greenfield, J. C. (1999). "Apkallu." [Dictionary of Deities and Demons in the Bible](#). Eerdmans. 72-73.

“These apkallu were the divine source of all of the wisdom that was passed onto the founders of Mesopotamian culture and empire. [T]he root of Mesopotamian knowledge unites divination, horoscopy, astronomy in a learned cuneiform tradition. This way of identifying knowledge ... was connected with the [apkallu], from whom all this knowledge was derived in the days before the flood.”

Rochberg, Francesca (2007). [The Heavenly Writing: Divination, Horoscopy, and Astronomy in Mesopotamian Culture](#). Cambridge University Press. 17.

There is an important Babylonian text that traces the lineage of the seven apkallu who are divine beings down to the post-flood kings of Mesopotamia, and the final four apkallu are called “of human descent ... two-thirds apkallu.” And not only this, but these post-flood human-divine hybrids are giants!



Jastrow (2006). [Wikipedia](#)

For example: The ancient Sumerian king Gilgamesh was portrayed in Sumerian mythology as part human, part god and really tall! See this depiction of Gilgamesh from the late Assyrian period, 8th century B.C.E. He is depicted as giant hunter with a lion and a snake in his hands. Gilgamesh's legacy is likely behind the portrait of Nimrod in Genesis 10:9-10, who built Babylon and Erech, which is the Hebrew spelling of Uruk, Gilgamesh's city.

Recommended Resources

Heiser, Michael (2017). *Reversing Hermon: Enoch, The Watchers, and the Forgotten Mission of Jesus Christ*. Defender. Chapter 3.

Annus, Amar (2010). "On the Origin of Watchers: A Comparative Study of the Antediluvian Wisdom in Mesopotamian and Jewish Traditions." *Journal for the Study of the Pseudepigrapha*, Volume 19.4. 277-320.

Conclusions About the Sons of *Elohim* and the Nephilim

“The reason Genesis 6:1-4 is in the Bible is because the writer sought to target the deeply held religious beliefs of Mesopotamia, and, most pointedly, the myth of Babylonian superiority ... ‘These accounts of the [pre-flood] history in ancient Mesopotamian and Jewish sources should be regarded as results of ancient debates. Not only direct borrowings took place, but also creative interpretations, especially on the Jewish side ... [T]hese were deliberate inversions of Mesopotamian traditions. The Jewish authors often inverted the Mesopotamian myths, with the intention of showing the superiority of their own cultural foundations ...’ The point was to turn the Mesopotamian belief system on its head, to make sure that Israelites and Jewish readers would know that what happened between the sons of God and the daughters of humankind was not something that bettered humanity. It was the opposite—a transgression of heaven and earth that would corrupt humankind and produce a lineage that would later become a threat to the very existence of Israel, Yahweh’s people and portion.”

Heiser, Michael (2017). [*Reversing Hermon: Enoch, The Watchers, and the Forgotten Mission of Jesus Christ*](#). Defender. 49-51. Includes an embedded quote by Annus, Amar (2010). [*“On the Origin of Watchers.” Journal for the Study of the Pseudepigrapha*](#), Volume 19:4. 277-320.

Genesis 6:1-4 is the introduction to the story of the flood, which begins in Genesis 6:5. In other words, the flood of divine justice is God’s response to human wickedness in general but also specifically to the outbreak of violence and war caused by the warrior giants, who were themselves the result of a transgression of the sons of *Elohim*.

The flood narrative is God’s attempt to purify the land from the innocent blood shed by the Nephilim and their violence. We are meant to see that many of the Nephilim perish in the flood. But in the Hebrew Bible, that doesn’t mean the end of their threat. As Genesis 6:4 notes, they are still around after the flood.

The Sons of *Elohim* and Nephilim and Spiritual Evil

These warriors go by many names: Emim, Anakim, and **Rephaim**. This last title is fascinating because it is most often used in the Bible to refer to the **spirits of dead warrior kings**.

Isaiah 26:13-14 NIV*

¹³ LORD our God, other lords besides you **have ruled over us**,
but your name alone do we honor.

¹⁴ They are now dead, they live no more;

the Rephaim do not rise.

You punished them and brought them to ruin;
you wiped out all memory of them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 14:9 NIV*

The realm of the dead below is all astir
to meet you at your coming;

it rouses **the Rephaim** to greet you—

all those who were **leaders in the world**;

it makes them rise from their thrones—
all those who were **kings over the nations**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 88:4-5, 10 NASB*

⁴ I am reckoned among those who go down to the pit;
I have become like a man without strength,
⁵ forsaken among the dead, like the slain who lie in the grave,
whom you remember no more, and they are cut off from your hand. ...
¹⁰ Will you perform wonders for the dead?
Will **the Rephaim** rise and praise you?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Hebrew Bible references God's judgment on the Rephaim as a banishment to the grave.

Ezekiel 32:26-27 NASB*

²⁶ Meshech, Tubal and all their hordes are there; their graves surround them. All of them were slain by the sword uncircumcised, though they instilled their terror in the land of the living. ²⁷ Nor do they lie beside **the fallen (naphal) warriors (gibborim)** of the uncircumcised, who **went down to Sheol** with their weapons of war and whose swords were laid under their heads; **but the punishment for their iniquity** rested on their bones, for the terror of these warriors was once in the land of the living.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 24:21-23 NASB

²¹ So it will happen in that day,
that the LORD will punish **the host of heaven on high,
and the kings of the earth on earth.**
²² They will be **gathered together
like prisoners in the dungeon,**
and will be **confined in prison;**
and after many days they will be punished.
²³ Then the moon will be abashed and the sun ashamed,
for the LORD of hosts will reign on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem,
and his glory will be before his elders.

These Rephaim, the surviving spirits in the realm of the dead, are associated with the Nephilim and the giant warrior kings who originated back in the spiritual rebellion of the sons of God in Genesis 6.

The Bible confirms that these Nephilim/Rephaim are corrupted spiritual beings when Peter and Jude refer back to them.

2 Peter 2:4-5 NASB*

⁴ For if God did not spare **angels when they sinned**, but cast them into **Tartarus** and **committed them to pits of darkness, reserved for judgment**; ⁵ and did not spare the ancient world, but preserved Noah, a preacher of righteousness, with seven others, when he brought a flood upon the world of the ungodly.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jude 1:6-7 NASB

⁶ And **angels who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper abode, he has kept in eternal bonds under darkness for the judgment of the great day**, ⁷ just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them, since they in the same way as these indulged in gross immorality and **went after strange flesh**, are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire.

Peter and Jude are reflecting on Genesis 6:1-4 and merging its ideas with the depictions of the Rephaim as spirits of the dead. Notice how Jude verse 7 has connected the two stories of the sons of God in Genesis 6 and the men of Sodom in Genesis 19.

Spiritual Rebels and Babylon

These giant warrior kings play a key role in the final human and spiritual rebellion narrative in Genesis 1-11: the founding of Babylon.

Consider the two stories about the foundation of the Babylonian empire in Genesis 10-11.

Genesis 10:6-10 NASB

⁶ The sons of **Ham** were **Cush** and Mizraim and Put and Canaan. ⁷ The sons of **Cush** were Seba and Havilah and Sabtah and Raamah and Sabteca; and the sons of Raamah were Sheba and Dedan. ⁸ Now **Cush** became the father of **Nimrod**; he became a mighty warrior on the earth. ⁹ He was a mighty warrior, a hunter before the LORD; therefore it is said, "Like Nimrod a mighty hunter before the LORD." ¹⁰ The beginning of his kingdom was Babylon and Erech and Accad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.

Genesis 11:1-4 NASB

¹ Now the whole earth used the same language and the same words. ² It came about as they journeyed east, that they found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there. ³ They said to one another, "Come, let us make bricks and burn them thoroughly." And they used brick for stone, and they used tar for mortar. ⁴ They said, "Come, **let us build for ourselves a city, and a tower whose top will reach into the heavens**, and let us make for ourselves a name, otherwise we will be scattered abroad over the face of the whole earth."

Links Back to Genesis 3 and 6

Nimrod is the grandson of Ham, Noah's son, and he is called a "mighty warrior" (Heb. *gibbor*), which is the same word used to describe the offspring of the sons of God and human women in Genesis 6:4! The rebel sons of God are behind the founding of Babylon just as they were behind the story of Genesis 6.

Nimrod, who is identified with the giants of Genesis 6, builds the kingdom of Babylon and Erech (Heb. אֶרֶךְ), which is the same as the ancient city of Uruk, where Gilgamesh the original giant king lived.

Genesis 11 gives us a complementary story of Babylon's origins. We're told the city and its temple tower was built in order to "have a top in the heavens." In other words, the temple tower of Babylon is portrayed as a human-made attempt to re-create Eden, the original mountain-temple where Heaven and Earth overlapped.

The idea that the foundation of Babylon was a joint human-spiritual rebellion is also made clear by the portrayal of the ruler of Babylon in Isaiah 14, which looks back at Genesis 10-11.

Isaiah 14:4-5, 12-15 NASB

⁴ You all will take up this taunt against the king of Babylon, and say,
"How the oppressor has ceased,
and how fury has ceased!

⁵ The LORD has broken the staff of the wicked the scepter of rulers ..."

¹² "How you have fallen from heaven,
O star of the morning, son of the dawn!
You have been cut down to the earth,
you who have weakened the nations!

¹³ But you said in your heart,
'I will ascend to the heavens;
I will raise my throne above the stars of God,
and I will sit on the mount of assembly
in the recesses of the north.

¹⁴ I will ascend above the heights of the clouds;
I will make myself like the Most High.'

¹⁵ Nevertheless you will be thrust down to Sheol,
to the recesses of the pit."

In this poem, Isaiah depicts the king of Babylon as a human rebel who embodies the spiritual rebel behind the origins of Babylon. Babylon is founded by Nimrod, a warrior giant associated with the Nephilim, and Babylon is built up as an anti-Eden in Genesis 11. The author of Isaiah is saying Babylon is more than just a human enterprise; it is an icon of the human and spiritual rebellion.

Conclusions About Spiritual and Human Evil in Genesis 1-11 and the Hebrew Scriptures

We have encountered multiple intertwined spiritual and human rebellions in Genesis 1-11.

In Genesis 3-4, the original spiritual rebel is a former exalted throne guardian of God's heavenly temple who resents being subservient to exalted humans. So he lures them into the same temptation he succumbed to, seizing authority by his own wisdom and abusing it for selfish purposes. We then watch humans replay this rebellion, first with Adam and Eve, and then with Cain's murder of his brother.

In Genesis 6 and 11, even more members of the divine council rebel in an intensification of the Genesis 3 rebellion. This results in the spread of creatures who are part spiritual being/part human and who spread violence through their empires, beginning with Babylon. As many of these beings die in the flood, their spirits live on in the underworld as terrifying monsters.

These narratives provide three categories of spiritual evil:

1. An arch-rebel depicted by the imagery of the snake (Gen. 3) and sin (Gen. 4).
2. Lower-level spiritual rebels who deceive humans into exalting their empires to divine status.
3. Deceased spirits of the Nephilim who endure a shadowy existence in the underworld.

Reflection Question

What are some of the notable characteristics of the legendary kings of the ancient Mesopotamian world?